the R&AW launched the first stage of Operation Farewell. The streets were filled with protesters demanding the resignation of Ershad and fresh elections in the country under the supervision of the United Nations. By the beginning of September 1990, highly trained and motivated R&AW officers including Patwardhan and Rakesh Dixit exhibited remarkable strategic depths by mounting pressure on Ershad's administration. By the beginning of October, the tirades against Ershad had amplified and engulfed the hinterland.

'Not only Ershad but even the ISI and CIA were petrified by the sudden change in the atmosphere,' recalled Patwardhan. 'We used our networks in the domestic and international media to fan the fire. Public outbursts on the pages of newspapers highlighted Ershad's sustained assault on democratic values. Although Ershad reacted sharply by raiding the residences of some over ground leaders to offset the pressure, it didn't work. The spark we ignited to restore democracy in the country had fired the people's consciences. For us, it was just another day at work, though some of our junior colleagues doubted that things would go as planned.'

To ensure that the iron masks of the R&AW spies remained impregnable, telephonic communications and public meetings were prohibited for all intelligence officers involved in Operation Farewell. Patwardhan said he didn't want to give Ershad and the Western intelligence agencies the joy of surveillance and eavesdropping. On 1 October 1990, Operation Farewell gained further momentum when the powerful student body Chhatra Dal cobbled together various unions under the Sarbadaliya Chhatra Oikya Parishad (All-party Students Council) and mounted unprecedented protests against Ershad's government. The Awami League and the BNP successfully